INSTRUCTOR LESSON PLAN

Many Plates Spinning

Builds: Work & Time Organization

A turnkey unit for teaching students to run two projects at once without dropping either one.

> **Builds:** Work & Time Organization **Grade band:** 6–12 (adaptation notes for grades 3–5 and college/CTE below) **Time:** 3 sessions of ~45 minutes, run as one project-management beat per week across roughly three weeks (not three days in a row) **Format:** Whole-class walkthrough → guided build with peer check → cold, self-directed setup by week three

Why this unit

This is the cliff from the keynote. Real work is never one assignment at a time — it's three or four projects with deadlines that collide, shift, and overlap. But school has only ever handed our students one thing at a time, neatly queued: finish this, then we'll give you the next thing. So they've never had to hold two open projects in their head, protect time for both, or decide what gives when a deadline moves. And next week they can't even find the file they made today — it's an "untitled" document somewhere on a desktop. This unit puts two real projects in the air at once and makes the *management* of them — the calendar, the task list, the named folder — the actual work. Work & Time Organization is the muscle that keeps everything else from falling on the floor.

Learning objective

By the end of week three, **students can run two concurrent projects with offset deadlines — keeping a live task list, protecting work time on a shared calendar, and storing every file in a named, organized place — and can adjust the plan in writing when a deadline moves** — without a teacher-provided template.

Materials & prep

Teacher prep (~20 min the first time, ~5 min after):

- Pick **two real, mid-length projects** students will work on concurrently with **offset deadlines** — Project A due near the end of week two, Project B due near the end of week three. They can be projects you were already assigning; the point is that the two timelines overlap. Write down both due dates.
- Set up (or designate) **one shared calendar** students can all see and add blocks to — your LMS calendar, a shared Google Calendar, or even a wall calendar with sticky notes. Decide the format before day one.
- Prepare **one sample calendar block and one sample folder structure** to walk through in week one (see the handout for the model). Make it deliberately boring and clear: a top folder named `Lastname–ProjectA`, subfolders, files named with a date and a version.
- Plan your **deadline shift in advance.** Midway through (early in week two), you will move **one** deadline by **two days** with no warning. Decide now which one and what the new date is, so you deliver it cleanly and consistently to everyone.
- Print the **Student Handout** (below), one per student, or post it to your LMS.

Students need: access to the shared calendar, a place to store digital files (or a physical folder/binder if you're offline), and something to keep a running task list on — paper or doc, their choice, but it has to be *live*, not redone from scratch each session.

The arc at a glance

Session	Focus	~Time
Week 1 — Model it	Teacher walks through a sample calendar block, task list, and folder structure; students set up both projects using the model	45 min
Week 2 — Build it (with the curveball)	Students build their own systems from scratch; 5-min peer comparison; teacher shifts one deadline by two days mid-session and students re-plan in writing	45 min
Week 3 — Run it cold	No templates — students stand up their own systems on day one and flag conflicts before they become crises	45 min

Step-by-step sequence

Week 1 — Model the system (45 min)

- **(5 min) Name the situation.** Tell students plainly: *"You're running two projects at the same time. They're due on different days, and both clocks are already ticking. Today we're not building the projects — we're building the system that keeps you from dropping one."* Show both due dates side by side.
- **(15 min) Walk the model.** On the screen, demonstrate three things slowly: (1) a **task list** with each task tagged to Project A or Project B, (2) a **calendar block** — pick a real day and time and put "Work on Project A" on the shared calendar so it's *protected* before the deadline arrives, and (3) a **folder structure** — a named top folder per project, sensible subfolders, and a file named so you could find it next week (`ProjectA_outline_2026-06-03`). Say out loud: *"No untitled files. Nothing dumped on the desktop. If you can't find it in ten seconds, it isn't stored."*
- **(20 min) Students set up both projects using the model.** Each student creates the two named folders, lists their starting tasks tagged by project, and adds at least **two** work blocks to the shared calendar — at least one for each project — before either deadline. Circulate and check that folders are named and tasks are tagged.
- **(5 min) Close the loop.** Quick whip-around: each student names one task they'll do first and which project it belongs to. Tell them: *"Next week you build this with no model — and there's a catch coming."*

Week 2 — Build from scratch, then the curveball (45 min)

- **(10 min) Rebuild without the template.** Students update their task lists and calendars from memory — no model on the screen this time. They should be carrying *both* projects forward, not starting over.
- **(5 min) Peer comparison.** In pairs, students swap screens for five minutes and answer two questions about each other's setup: *"Could you find this person's most recent file in ten seconds?"* and *"Is there protected calendar time for both projects?"* Each student fixes one thing their partner flagged.
- **(5 min) The deadline shift.** Now deliver the curveball, no warning: *"Heads up — Project [A/B] is now due two days [earlier/later]. New date is ___."* Let it land. This is the lesson.
- **(20 min) Re-plan in writing.** Students adjust their task lists and calendar blocks to the new date, *and* write a short trade-off note: **what they moved, what they had to give up or push, and why.** Require them to name the conflict the shift created (e.g., "both projects now need work on Thursday"). This written trade-off is the heart of the unit.
- **(5 min) Surface the trade-offs.** Two or three students read their trade-off note aloud. Ask: *"What did the shift force you to decide that you wouldn't have had to decide if the projects were queued one at a time?"*

Week 3 — Run it cold (45 min) — ***fully released***

- **(5 min) No scaffolding.** Remind students of both live deadlines. No model, no template, no pair check unless they ask for it.
- **(25 min) Stand up the system solo and work.** Each student, on their own: confirms a named folder and current files for each project, a live task list tagged by project, and protected calendar blocks for both — then works the actual projects in their protected time.
- **(15 min) Flag conflicts before they're crises.** Each student writes a short **conflict scan**: where do the two timelines collide in the days ahead, and what's their plan to handle it *now* rather than the night before? Collect the scan alongside their calendar and task list.

Student handout (copy-ready)

> **Many Plates Spinning**
>
> You're running **two projects at the same time.** They're due on different days, and both clocks are already ticking. Your job is to keep both plates spinning — not by working harder, but by building a system you can trust.
>
> **Your two projects and their due dates:** *(your teacher will give you these)*
>
> **Part 1 — The task list (keep it live).** Write every task you can think of for both projects. Tag each one **(A)** or **(B)** so you always know which project it belongs to. Update this list every session — don't start a new one each time.
>
> **Part 2 — Protect the time.** On the shared calendar, add at least **two work blocks** before your deadlines — at least one for each project. A block means: *this time is reserved, and I will not give it away.* Protect the time **before** the deadline arrives, not after.
>
> **Part 3 — Store it so you can find it.** Make one **named folder per project** (use your name and the project). Inside, name every file so you'd find it next week — include what it is and the date: `ProjectA_outline_2026-06-03`. The rules: **no "untitled" files. Nothing left on the desktop. If you can't find it in ten seconds, it isn't really stored.**
>
> **Part 4 — When a deadline moves (it will).** If a due date changes, don't panic and don't redo everything. Adjust your task list and calendar, then write three sentences:
>
> 1. What I moved.
> 2. What I had to give up or push back — and the conflict it created.
> 3. Why I made that trade instead of another one.
>
> **Part 5 — Scan for conflicts early.** Look ahead: where do your two projects need you at the same time? Name the collision now and write your plan to handle it — *before* it becomes a crisis the night before.

What proficient looks like (teacher look-fors)

- The student keeps **one live task list** carried forward week to week — not rebuilt from scratch — with every task **tagged** to a project.
- Work time is **blocked on the calendar before** the deadline, not scrambled for after.
- Every file lives in a **named folder** with a **findable name** — you (or they) can locate the latest version in ten seconds. No "untitled," no desktop dumps.
- When you **move a deadline**, the student **adjusts the plan in writing** and can **name the trade-off** they made instead of restarting or freezing.
- By week three, the student **flags a looming conflict early** instead of discovering it the night before.

Assessment

Score with `toolkit/rubrics.md`, one cluster, no separate grade required — lay it over the work students already produced:

- **Work & Time Organization →** *"...use a calendar to protect work time before deadlines arrive."*, *"...organize files so work can be found again without a search."*, and *"...track open tasks across more than one project at a time."*

Proficient = does it independently this time. **Advanced** = proactively surfaces conflicts before you raise them and keeps collaborators informed of changes as they happen.

The rubric for this unit

Lay these competency rows over the work students already produced — no separate assignment. **Proficient** is the target (demonstrated and independent); **Advanced** means the student extends the skill unprompted.

Work & Time Organization

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...use a calendar to protect work time before deadlines arrive.	Does not use a calendar; all planning is in their head or not at all.	Has deadlines written down but does not block time in advance to do the work.	Adds working sessions to a calendar before deadlines arrive and notices when two projects collide.	Proactively protects time weeks out, flags conflicts to collaborators early, and adjusts when new demands appear.
...organize files so work can be found again without a search.	Files are untitled, saved to a default location, or simply lost; cannot locate own work.	Files are saved but named inconsistently; finding them takes trial and error.	Files are named clearly and stored in a folder structure they can describe to someone else; nothing important is lost.	Maintains a system others could navigate, versions work intentionally, and can explain the logic of their structure.
...track open tasks across more than one project at a time.	Loses track of what is due when managing more than one assignment.	Tracks due dates individually but misses that two land on the same day or require shared prep time.	Maintains a running task list across all projects and updates it regularly without reminders.	Uses their system to proactively surface conflicts, reprioritize, and keep collaborators informed.

Gradual release across the three weeks

	Teacher provides	Student provides
Week 1	Walks through a sample calendar block, task list, and folder structure; students copy the model	Both systems set up with heavy support, following the model
Week 2	No template on screen; 5-min peer comparison; shifts one deadline by two days with no warning	Systems rebuilt from scratch; a written trade-off note after the deadline shift
Week 3	Nothing — no templates, both deadlines live	Systems stood up solo on day one; a written conflict scan flagging collisions early

The goal is that by week three, protecting time and naming files isn't an assignment — it's just how the student works.

Differentiation & adaptation

- **Grades 3–5:** Use two short, familiar projects (a poster and a class-store display) with deadlines a few days apart. Keep the folder structure to one named folder per project and skip versioned file names. Do the calendar on a shared wall calendar with sticky notes so "protecting time" is physical and visible.

- **College / CTE:** Use real overlapping deliverables from a capstone, internship, or shop rotation. Require a shared project-management tool (a board or shared calendar the whole team can see), and make the trade-off note a brief stakeholder update — *who needs to know this deadline moved, and what did you tell them?*
- **Multilingual learners / IEPs:** Provide a task-list template with the **(A)/(B)** tags pre-printed and sentence stems for the trade-off note ("I moved ___ because ___; this means ___ now has to ___"). Scaffold the form without doing the planning for them.
- **Time-crunched version:** Run only Week 1 (model) and Week 2 (build + curveball) as a single block on the launch day of two projects you were already assigning. The deadline shift alone teaches the core lesson.

Common pitfalls

- **Letting students rebuild the list each week.** The point is a *live* system carried forward. If they start fresh every session, they never feel the weight of holding two projects at once.
- **Queuing the projects one at a time anyway.** If the two timelines don't actually overlap, the unit collapses back into school-as-usual. Keep the deadlines offset and concurrent.
- **Warning students about the deadline shift.** The surprise is the curriculum. If they see it coming, you've taught them to plan for a known change, not to absorb a real one.
- **Grading the trade-off note for the "right" decision.** Grade it for being *adjusted in writing, named, and reasoned* — not for matching the choice you would have made.

The low-lift version (if you have no room for the full unit)

Take any project you already assign and require a **"plan-before-you-start" memo**: one calendar block for the work time and the named file location where the work will live — submitted *before* a single thing gets built. That's the Plan-Before-You-Start weave-in move — the entire unit compressed into one sentence of required planning.